

joked, to keep Verstappen from passing out. The chasing helicopter edged closer. That's when Lakshmi Mittal saw the machine-guns.

He grabbed the intercom to speak to the pilot, Nik Bowe.... 'They say we've strayed into military airspace,' Bowe called back to him over the noise of the twin engines. 'They're forcing us down.' Bowe could hear the other pilot ordering the control tower to give Mittal's helicopter a landing slot immediately. He was bringing in a suspicious aircraft.

Mittal could see the headlines now. 'Billionaire Indian Industrialist

'But France is a civilised country, Mr Mittal.'

'The most civilised,' Mittal agreed, ushering Roland Verstappen to a waiting car.

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He was delighted when he got a call from Prime Minister Singh, India's first Sikh premier, asking if he would attend an official lunch he was giving for **PRIME TIME: Mittal with Manmohan**

quest that you do not attend the lunch today.' Mittal demanded that he explain himself. The 'request' had come from the very top, he was told. Chirac did not want to meet him. His presence there would be considered 'unfortunate'.

Mittal was in a dilemma. He could either risk upsetting his Prime Minister by not attending the lunch or he could turn up and cause a diplomatic rumpus with the French, whom, in spite of governmental intransigence, he still believed he could woo to his bid for Arcelor. He put business before political patronage, and chose the latter.

That evening he was at a drinks reception when he saw the seventy-four-year-old Manmohan Singh making a beeline for him. 'You did not come for the lunch,' the Prime Minister said. Mittal apologised profusely and hinted at the French phone call. Ever the stealth diplomat, he also saw an opportunity. 'I would like to meet you officially sometime tomorrow and explain everything,' he said.

He had his wish. The PM would see him just before his official bilateral talks with Chirac at Hyderabad House, the palace built by Edwin Lutyens in 1926 and now used by the government of India for banquets and meetings with visiting foreign dignitaries.

Mittal was there promptly. He met Singh for just a few minutes but it gave him the chance to pres-

ent his case for taking over Arcelor, to brief the Prime Minister on his meeting with Thierry Breton, and to explain that his non-attendance at the lunch was just the latest episode in the French government's hostile reaction to his bid. Singh agreed that he would indeed raise the issues with Chirac. At the beginning of their meeting Mittal had thought that at least if he could not get to Chirac directly to discuss his bid, this was the next-best thing. Now when he shook hands with Singh and prepared to leave he had changed his mind. Having a prime minister do it for you was an even better thing.



Mittal's non-attendance at the lunch hosted for Chirac was another episode in France's hostile reaction to his bid.

Arrested for Espionage', 'Mittal Now Being Questioned by Security Services'.

Once they landed it was Bowe who was taken away for questioning as the military helicopter flew away. As soon as the immigration official saw Mittal's passport, he said, 'You're Lakshmi Mittal. We know who you are, you can go.'

'Thank goodness this isn't America, where they shoot first and ask questions later,' Mittal smiled.

Chirac on Sunday 19 February.... Singh's lunch could also give Mittal the chance to meet another world leader and maybe persuade Jacques Chirac that his bid for Arcelor posed no threat to anybody's job, that no plants would be closed.... His thoughts were suddenly interrupted. His phone was ringing. The voice on the other end of the line was not Indian.

'Mr Mittal,' the high-ranking French government official said, 'we re-

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